

After the session: what we did and why

1 The purpose of Business Analysis

Business analysis is the discipline of making sure the right problem gets solved for the organisation. The session ran the four stages in order. That chain, from problem to decision, is what matters most. If any link is missing you cannot say afterwards whether the work was worth doing.

What a BA is there to do at each stage:

1 Discover

Understand the problem, the people and the data before anyone commits to a solution.

2 Define

Turn the agreed problem into a solution the organisation can build and test, with the trade-offs made explicit.

3 Build

Make sure what gets built corresponds with what was defined, down to the detail.

4 Evaluate

Reflect rigorously on what was built, judge what happened and decide the best next move.

2 Discover: understand before we build

The brief arrived as a solution: a booking platform. Discover is where we refuse to take that at face value and find out what is actually going on.

TOOLS WE USED

- **Stakeholder map.** Who can stop this, and who cares? Power against interest, so we know whom to keep close and whom to keep informed.

- **Interviews.** Stakeholders tell us what outcomes really matter for them. Users tell us what happened last time. Both are evidence; neither is the whole story.
- **Data analysis.** What the numbers can and cannot answer. Incomplete, fuzzy data is normal. The skill is knowing which gaps matter, and being sceptical about broad conclusions from narrow data.
- **As-is process map.** Where the current process hurts, step by step, and for whom.
- **Risky assumptions.** The beliefs the whole idea rests on, ranked by how much damage they do if wrong, with the cheapest way to test each. Test these cheaply before the expensive build starts.

EXERCISES WE DID

- Placed ten stakeholders on the power-against-interest grid.
- Interviewed the CFO and the reception desk in role-play, five minutes each, using the tips below.
- Read the data pack, noticed what was missing, and took the true/false quiz.
- Annotated the as-is process map with a pain point at every step.
- Ranked the risky assumptions from riskiest to least risky, with the cheapest test for each.
- Wrote the problem statement together.

Interview tips worth keeping

People are closest to the detail, so getting accurate information from them is key in discovery.

Tips for interviewing stakeholders

- Start with what they want solved, not what they want built. "What outcome do you want to get at, and by when?"
- Separate any solution they arrive with from the problem underneath it: "If the platform did not exist, what would still be true?"
- Play back what you heard in their words and check it. Senior people correct you quickly, and the correction is the useful bit.
- Write down any number they mention. They are usually important for a reason.

Tips for interviewing users

- Try asking about the last time rather than what they usually do. Memories of specific events tend to be more honest than generalisations.
- Walk through it step by step where you can. "What happened next?" often gets further than "why?"
- Leave a silence where it feels natural. The second answer is often the real one.
- Where you can, write down exact words. A quote in the problem statement tends to carry more weight than a summary.

Our problem statement

Rallying everyone around a shared problem to solve is the natural endpoint of a discovery.

Who: residents. **Needs to:** book seamlessly and easily. **Because:** they need to play more sport. **Today they:** don't play sport. **Which results in:** lack of inclusion, lack of health, and lower revenues for the council.

REFLECTIONS

Stakeholder maps are fluid and ongoing. Someone may have more power or interest than their title suggests, and both change over time: a new cabinet member, a budget round, a complaint that lands on the wrong desk. Redraw the map as we learn, rather than filing it after week one.

The as-is map is where we go deeper than anyone else. Every pain point got a why, and then another why, until we reached something a stakeholder could act on (the 5 Whys). Then the job flips: package it up for the stakeholder. What is the headline? If the map cannot be summarised in one sentence they will remember, it is not finished.

Where we might face pushback. The CFO will push back on the consequences: 'lower revenues' has no number against it, and nothing in the statement says how much cost the platform is expected to take out. Reception will push back on 'book seamlessly and easily', which sounds like a website replacing the desk; they need to hear that the phone stays open. And keeping 'residents' and 'play more sport' this wide felt safe in the room, but it costs later: Define forces trade-offs (who first, which need first) that a wide problem statement has not made, so every one of those decisions has to be argued from scratch.

3 Define: decide what to build first

Define takes the agreed problem and defines a solution that can solve it. Every choice here is a trade-off, and the point of writing it down is so we can say later who it was for and who lost out.

TOOLS WE USED

- **User groups and user needs.** Who the solution is for, in priority order, and what each group needs from it.
- **Business needs.** What the organisation needs from it, in priority order, and who disagrees.
- **Theory of change.** If we do this, then people will do that, because of this belief, leading to this outcome.
- **To-be process map.** The UX colleague's first draft of how the process works once the solution exists.
- **User story map with acceptance criteria.** The PM's stories along the journey, with a line between the MVP and later.
- **Success measures.** What we will count, and where the number comes from.

EXERCISES WE DID

Ranked the user groups

1. **Regular bookers (primary: the MVP is designed around them).** Residents who already book by phone or at the desk, often weekly. Many are in clubs or informal groups. Skew older.
2. **Reception staff.** The people who take bookings, answer the phone and run the buildings, alongside unlocking gates and first aid.

3. **Other residents.** Residents who do not currently use council sports facilities: casual players, families with children, the over-50s, people who have never been in the building.

Ranked the business needs

1. **Decreased costs.** Ranked first by the group: the platform is funded as a cost-reduction showcase, and the theory of change leads with costs.
2. **Increased revenue.** Ranked second: fewer empty slots and online payment both put money back into the budget.
3. **More inclusion for the community.** Ranked third: wanted, but the group expects it to follow from an easier service rather than drive the build.
4. **Healthier children.** Ranked fourth. The group's words: if Public Health funded this, they would have their priorities top. This is where Public Health will disagree.
5. **Support public health for the over-50s.** Ranked fifth. Same reasoning: whoever pays sets the order, and Public Health is not paying. Public Health and the Cabinet Member will push back on this order hardest.

Wrote our theory of change

IF WE

Implement a booking platform online.

THEN

More people book pitches and fewer people phone in. Some of these people will be children or older people.

BECAUSE

It is more seamless and they don't need to phone up anymore.

LEADING TO

Costs will decrease and revenues will increase.

In one line: If we implement an online booking platform, more people will book pitches and fewer will phone in, because it is more seamless, leading to lower costs and higher revenue.

Critiqued the UX colleague's to-be process map

What we said, with a note on each point.

"Include cancellations and a 24-hour confirm-your-booking. This will stop the no-shows."
Attacks the no-show pain point directly, and it is cheap. Worth checking whether 'stop' is realistic: a reminder usually reduces no-shows rather than ending them.

"The repeat feature needs different recurring options, and perhaps an end date."

A real need from regular bookers, and a scope risk: every option is a screen to design, test and explain at the desk.

"Introduce paying online to drive up revenue. It should stop no-shows too."

Two claims in one. Payment may raise revenue and it may cut no-shows, but they are separate beliefs and the pilot should test them separately.

"Block no-show accounts."

A policy, not a feature. Who decides, after how many, and what about people who book by phone and never had an account?

"Get more information: an indication of age."

Needed for the over-50s measure. The site already asked for it, which shows how a measure drives a form field.

"It is not clear about the storing of the name. Is it secure?"

The right instinct, and a question the to-be map did not answer. Data protection is part of the process, not something added afterwards.

"When they turn up and pay, how is it logged against the booking? What is the pay system?"

A gap in the UX colleague's map. Reception needs a step that ties a desk payment to a booking, or the till and the diary drift apart again.

"What is the process for walk-ins? Let's have a check-availability-before-you-come feature."

Turns a wasted journey into an informed one, and it is the same screen as the slot picker, so it costs almost nothing extra.

"We need a reporting mechanism and a dashboard, joining up the data to show the end."

Without it there is nothing to evaluate against. It is also the piece most teams leave until last, then regret.

"A reception view to book in sessions from phones and walk-ins, and amend them too."

The step that makes 'one record of bookings' true. Without it, the platform is a second diary.

Critiqued the PM's story map

Stories above the line are the MVP. Everything else waits until the evidence says it is needed.

In the MVP (12)

- S1 See the facilities I can book
- S3 See free slots for the next 14 days
- S13 Book a midday over-50s session
- S5 Book with name, email, postcode and age group
- S6 Pay online
- S7 Get a reference on screen
- S8 Confirm or cancel 24 hours before
- S9 Cancel my booking
- S14 Repeat my booking until an end date
- S11 Reception sees online bookings
- S12 Block bookings for clubs
- S15 Reception books and amends phone and walk-in bookings

Later (5)

- S2 Filter by activity near me
- S4 Join a waiting list for a full slot
- S10 Change my booking
- S16 Flag residents who repeatedly no-show
- S17 See a bookings and income dashboard

“Pay online should be MVP.”

Adds a payment provider, refunds and reconciliation to the first build. It tests the belief that paying up front changes behaviour.

“Reminders should be MVP.”

Cheap, and it tests the belief that people forget rather than choose not to come.

“Block bookings should be MVP.”

Serves clubs and regular bookers, the group we put first. It tests whether regulars will move online if their season is protected.

Chose our success measures

Measure	Source	Commentary
Reception satisfaction	Survey before-and-after.	Puts employees at the centre, and a before-and-after study seems right. It will have a small sample and depend on the completion rate, with a risk that the least happy do not engage.
Increase in over-50s bookings	Data provided at checkout.	There is no baseline, because the paper diary never recorded age, so the first six weeks only give us a starting point.
% of people using online booking vs walk-in vs phone calls	Online system records this.	A powerful measure to look at channel shift, but not change in total volumes.
Decrease in time spent on bookings	Survey from reception staff	A proxy for the cost saving the CFO wants, but staff time freed is not the same as staff cost saved, and it is self-reported.
Decrease in costs	From their recorded quarterly cost sheets	What the CFO will actually look at. Quarterly, so a six-week pilot cannot show it moving; either the pilot runs longer or a proxy such as reception hours stands in.
Increase in revenue	From their revenue sheets	A good outcome measure, but it could be hard to draw the causal chain back to the solution.
Failure demand on the online booking	Abandoned journeys in Google Analytics	Great for measuring how the solution is being interacted with, but what is a 'good' number here?

REFLECTIONS

Ranking the groups is a decision, and a contentious one. Putting regular bookers first protects the people who use the service today and keeps the CFO's revenue safe. A different room might have put other residents first to chase inclusion, or reception staff first so that the change does not disrupt the desk. Each order serves a different business need, which is why the two rankings have to be made together.

Three stories, three different beliefs, three different build costs. Moving them all above the line makes the MVP bigger and the first pilot slower. That is the trade-off we accepted in order to chase costs and revenue first; a room that had put inclusion first would have made a different call.

A good spread across staff, users, money and the health of the service itself. None of the seven has a target or a baseline yet, and that is the next conversation to have with the CFO and with reception, because measures cannot be defined after the fact: you cannot turn back time to collect a baseline you did not ask for.

4 Build: the smallest thing that tests the idea

AI built the booking site from the definition we provided and nothing else: our user group order, our theory of change, the stories we put above the MVP line and the measures we chose. Then we tested it against what we had defined.

EXERCISES WE DID

The journey we tested: Check what is free → Pick a date and time → Enter your details → Pay and confirm

Things we caught in testing

- Under-18s could book the over-50s midday session. The age question was on the form, but nothing used the answer.
- Payment did not work as the acceptance criteria said. The confirmation said 'paid', but no payment was taken.

REFLECTIONS

This is why BAs get into the detail of the implementation as well as the definition: so that we catch these, not users. An acceptance criterion is only useful if somebody checks it against the real thing.

5 Evaluate: did it work, and for whom?

Evaluation is about reflecting rigorously on the build to make judgements and decide the best next move for Brent.

TOOLS WE USED

Four questions, asked in order. Skip one and the numbers will answer a question we never asked.

1. What did we set out to do?
2. What do the numbers say?
3. What do the numbers not tell us?
4. So what next?

EXERCISES WE DID

Questioning the causal chain

Link	Our claim	The evaluation question
If we	Implement a booking platform online.	Did we actually build and run it? Did people find it?
then	More people book pitches and fewer people phone in. Some of these people will be children or older people.	Did the behaviour change? For whom? Compared with what?
because	It is more seamless and they don't need to phone up anymore.	Was the belief right? What did users say the barrier was?
leading to	Costs will decrease and revenues will increase.	Did the outcome move, or did activity just move channel?

The pilot results we were shown

Fictional, generated from our measures. Every result comes with a *but*.

- **Reception satisfaction:** 3.8 / 5 reception satisfaction after six weeks, from 3.3 in the before-survey.
But: Only 6 of the 11 receptions answered the after-survey, and the two busiest sites are missing.
- **Increase in over-50s bookings:** 19% of bookings were by people over 50.
But: Almost all of them still booked by phone. Online bookings by the over-50s were 4%.
- **% of people using online booking vs walk-in vs phone calls:** 54% of bookings were made online by week six; 31% by phone, 15% walk-in.
But: Most of the online bookings are regulars who used to phone. Walk-ins barely moved, and the over-50s still phone 84% of the time.
- **Decrease in time spent on bookings:** -9 hrs a week spent on bookings across the borough, from about 40 to 31, as reported by reception.
But: Self-reported. Reception says most of the time freed went on helping people with the website instead.
- **Decrease in costs:** -£700 total running cost over six weeks compared with last year, after £3,100 of reception time freed and £2,400 of floodlit hours lost to no-shows.
But: The platform's licence and support cost of about £1,500 a quarter is not yet in the finance spreadsheet.
- **Increase in revenue:** +£6,200 income from casual bookings over six weeks compared with last year.
But: Most of it is bookings that used to come in by phone. Net new income is closer to £900.
- **Failure demand on the online booking:** 27% of started bookings were abandoned before confirmation; one in six of those left at the payment step.
But: Analytics cannot tell someone who gave up from someone who only came to check availability and left happy.

So what next?

Invest, iterate, pause, pivot or stop.

What we decided. We agreed to wait for more data, in particular a like-for-like comparison and the first quarterly cost and revenue figures, and then look to iterate rather than invest or stop.

REFLECTIONS

The causal chain. Understanding and reflecting on the chain from feature, to user behaviour, to organisation outcome is powerful. It is how we make sure we drive outcomes that matter and realise the potential benefits, rather than shipping features and hoping.

It is easy to draw incorrect conclusions from data. A number that looks like success can be any of these instead:

Substitution	Four in five online bookings replaced phone and walk-in bookings. Of the revenue rise, most is money that would have arrived by phone. The over-50s who came to the new sessions mostly booked by phone too, so the website's share of the inclusion result is small.
Counterfactual	The midday over-50s sessions and the £3 price started the same week as the platform. The data cannot separate the session, the price and the booking tool. A pilot with the sessions but no website would have told us more.
Novelty	Weeks 1 and 2 were the busiest for the midday sessions after a leaflet drop at two GP surgeries. Weeks 5 and 6 were flat. Whether the over-50s keep coming is unknown.
Self-report	Age group is self-declared at checkout and parents book for children, so the under-18 figure counts bookings, not children. First-time status is self-reported too.
Seasonality	The pilot ran in weeks when pitch demand changes anyway: lighter evenings, school terms, weather. A rise or fall against the same weeks last year may be the season, not the platform, so the comparison has to be with a like-for-like period and, ideally, with sites that did not get the platform.

Analysing versus deciding. There is a trade-off between analysing and deciding. More data is always available and it is hard to know when enough is enough. Waiting has a cost, in staff time and in a pilot that drifts. Deciding too early has a cost too. The job is to name in advance what evidence would be enough to commit, then commit when it arrives.

6 Things we discussed that weren't included

All very much needed. They add to what we did; they do not replace it.

Non-functional requirements	Performance, accessibility, security, resilience. The story map says what the service does; NFRs say how well it has to do it, and they are usually where the cost hides.
Getting through the Technical Design Authority	Any real build at Brent goes through architecture and security review. The BA's job is to have the requirements and the trade-offs written down clearly enough that the review is quick.
Getting a business case signed off	The size of the prize, the costs and the risks, in the format finance expects. The problem statement and the measures are the raw material; the case is a separate document with a separate audience.
Reporting	Who needs to know what, how often, and in what form, from the first week of the pilot. We touched on the dashboard in the process feedback; the reporting rhythm around it is its own piece of work.

7 Ten key takeaways

1. Start with the problem and desired outcomes, not solutions.
2. Ask what outcome the sponsor wants to get at, and by when.
3. Users are experts in what they do. They are not experts in what needs to happen, or in what other people do.
4. Dealing with patchy data in discovery is expected, so rigorous thinking and a sceptical mind are needed.
5. A problem statement should aspire to bring the CFO and the reception staff into a common cause.
6. Prioritising means something loses. Name what, and say it out loud before the build, not after.
7. Every link in a theory of change is a claim you can test. Think carefully about how change flows from feature, to user behaviour, to business outcome.

8. Acceptance criteria are only useful if tested rigorously. BAs need to get into the detail of a solution so we catch issues, not users!
9. Thinking carefully about success measures is vital for evaluation. You can't turn back time to define better ones.
10. Evaluation is tricky. Balancing being decisive and being rigorous is something your recommendations will need to consider.

The booking system, data and results in the session were fictional. Handout generated 2026-09-04.